Introduction: The Elephant and its Parts

> There was a great city in the country of Ghur, in which all the people were blind. A certain king passed by that place, bringing his army and pitching his camp on the plain. He had a large and magnificent elephant to minister to his pomp and excite awe, and to attack in battle. A desire arose among the people to see this monstrous elephant, and a number of the blind, like fools, visited it, every one running in his haste to find out its shape and form. They came, and being without the sight of their eyes groped about it with their hands; each of them by touching one member obtained a notion of some one part; each one got a conception of an impossible object, and fully believed his fancy true.[1]

This version of the well-known parable of the blind men and the elephant comes from the long *mathnavi* titled *Hadiqat al-Haqiqa*, the ambitious last work of the poet Majdud ibn Adam Ghaznavi (*c.* 1087–1130/1140 CE), best known by his '*urf*, Sana'i.[2] It is a fitting point of departure for the ensuing project on the Shansabanis of Ghur, or the "Ghurids" as they are commonly denoted in modern scholarship (but not here, for reasons discussed below). Sana'i not only located the didactic story in Ghur – whence unfolded the historical processes plotted in these two volumes – the parable itself appears to have been transposed from the Buddhist *Udana*, among the earliest compilations of the Enlightened One's solemn utterances.[3]

In his intellectual inspirations for *Hadiqat*, Sana'i enacted the perennial continuity of sources and realities,[4] many defined as non-Islamic and thus frequently understudied by modern "Islamicists" and others as they investigate cultural productions emerging from the vast geography of Islamic-Persianate Eurasia. Surely the poet would have been pleased to know that, almost a millennium after his own lifetime, his selection[5] of the elephant parable still provides a compelling homily: for our purposes, Sana'i succinctly and humorously exposed our figurative blindness, born of our temporal distance from the historical pasts we are trying to access – a blindness that is arguably compounded by the increasingly narrow scholarly specializations mobilized to attempt such recoveries.